
“All I ask of fate is that I may
be killed **leading a cavalry**
charge.”

JEB STUART, ON BECOMING COLONEL OF 1ST VIRGINIA CAVALRY,
1861

With his plumed hat and golden spurs, his setters, and tame raccoon, James Ewell Brown Stuart seemed more the leader of a hunting party than a cavalry chief. His retinue included a banjo player, a band, and a Prussian giant, Major Heros von Borcke. The flamboyant Jeb—as he was known from the initials of his name—styled himself a Virginia cavalier. In battle, though, Stuart pushed his men hard and himself harder. And he gleaned such valuable intelligence about enemy dispositions that General Robert E. Lee dubbed him the “eyes and ears” of his army.

Serving under Lee

Stuart was one of 11 children born to the politician Archibald Stuart and Elizabeth Pannill. He grew up in an enslaving family (and was later an enslaver himself of a small number of people) and was educated at home before attending college. As a cadet at West Point from 1850, he met Robert E. Lee, the military academy’s superintendent, who noticed that the young horseman from Virginia had acquired many demerits before he graduated in 1854.

In 1859, after five years fighting Indians on the frontier, Stuart, by now a lieutenant, was ordered to join Lee in putting down John Brown’s raid on Harpers Ferry. In June 1862, Lee, now in command of the battered Confederate army during the Peninsula Campaign, turned to Stuart to gather intelligence.

As a cavalry officer, Stuart had already distinguished himself during First Bull Run: he screened General Joseph E. Johnston’s